



python essentials: types, strings, lists

LING 430 Computational Linguistics Fall 2026

lecture 2a

Sep 1 2026

Siyu Liang

siyu.liang@rice.edu



last time

- functions: `print`, `len`, `type`, `split`, `set`
- variables and assignment

agenda

- variables & types
- numbers
- strings
- lists



today's notebook

- course website → week 2 → opens in Colab
- **File → Save a copy in Drive**



variables & types

variable

- using an **alphanumeric name** to stand in for a **value**
- value could be a number, a string, a list, ...

```
num = 17
```

```
num_add = num + 4
```

```
num_add
```

→ 21

- reassigning a name discards the old value

```
num = 3
```

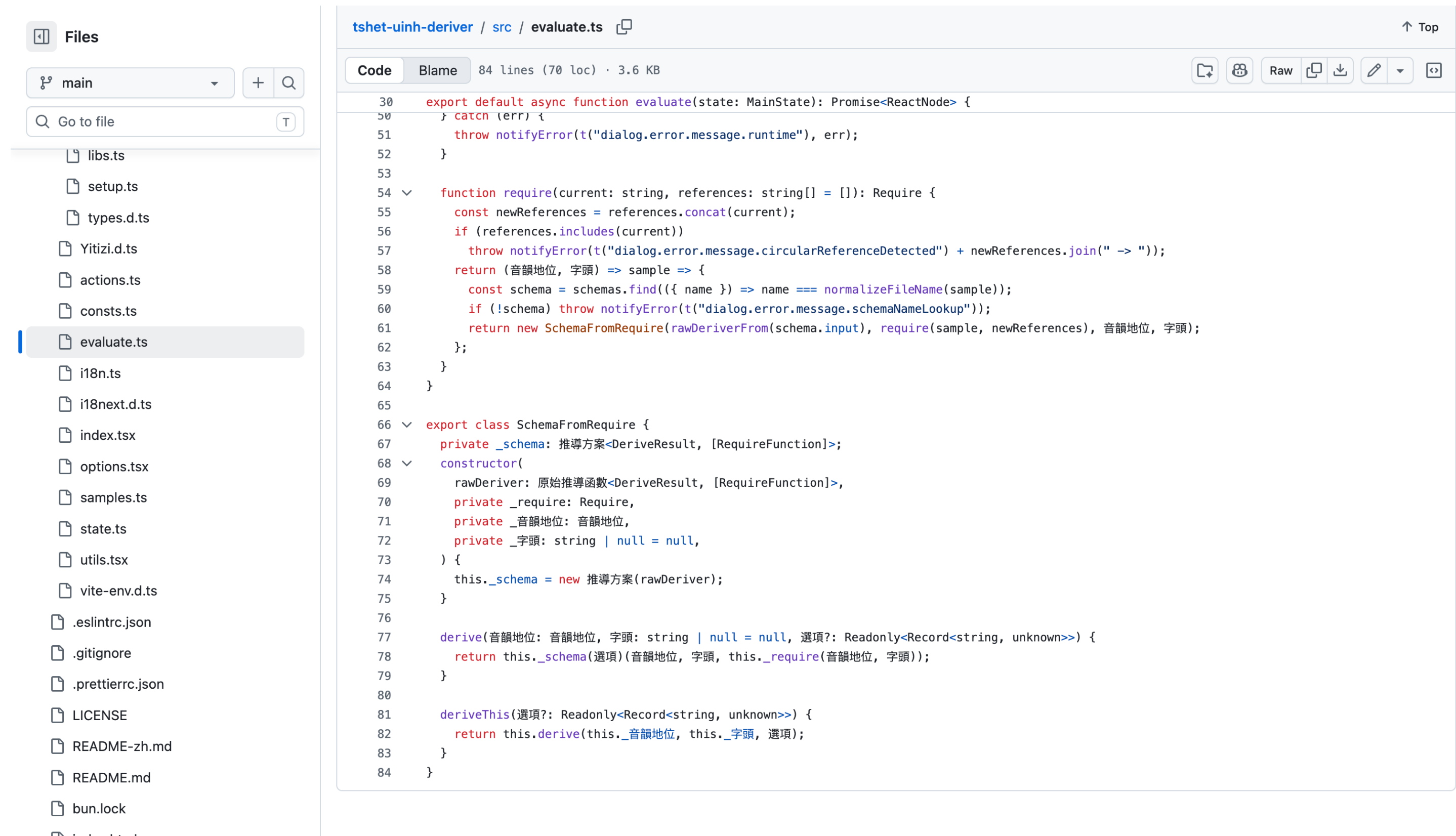
```
num
```

→ 3

variable

- variable names don’t have to be in English

あ = "a" 



naming things well

- variables should be **informative**
 - words, counts, stem
- bad choices confuse you later
 - x, data2, final_final
- name for the reader
 - ...who is usually future you



Stop, Drop, and Use a Versioning System
@redpen blackpen

type

- tells you **what kind of thing** something is

```
type("Odyssey")
```

→ str (a string)

```
type(7)
```

→ int (an integer)

- quotes matter!
 - "7" is text, 7 is a number

type

- types are determined **automatically** in Python

```
x = 17
```

```
type(x)
```

→ int

```
x = "seventeen"
```

```
type(x)
```

→ str

type

- each type's name doubles as a converter function
- can be helpful to fix **TypeError**s such as in "rose" + 3

```
float(3)
```

→ 3.0

```
int(42.1)
```

→ 42

```
str(42)
```

→ '42'

```
round(2/3, 2)
```

→ 0.67

type

recap

Object type	Example creation
Numbers (int, float)	123, 3.14
Strings	<code>"this class is cool"</code>
Lists (incl. nested)	<code>[1, 2, [1, 2]]</code>
Dictionaries	<code>{"1": "abc", "2": "def"}</code>
Tuples	<code>(1, "Test", 2)</code>
Files	<code>open("file.txt"), open("file.txt", "w")</code>
Sets	<code>set('a', 'b', 'c')</code>
Others	boolean, None
Program unit types	functions, modules, classes



expressions vs statements

- an *expression* has a value

```
len(word), "rose" * 3
```

- a *statement* does something

```
word = "hello"
```

- a cell shows the value of its last **expression**
 - which is why some cells print without `print()`



numbers

int & float

- `int`
 - whole and exact, e.g., counts
`type(42)`
→ `int`
- `float`
 - decimal, e.g., probability
`type(42.0)`
→ `float`
- division always returns a `float`, even when it comes out even
- mostly because you want to be consistent
`84 / 2`
→ `42.0`

operator

- symbols or keywords that perform a specific action on values

`6 * 7`

→ 42

`84 / 2`

→ 42.0

`2 ** 10`

→ 1024

`count == 2`

→ True

operator

- floor

`7 // 4`

→ 1

- modulus

`7 % 4`

→ 3

`8 % 4`

→ 0

comparisons

- you can use operators to compare variables
- the answers will validate to `True` or `False`, of the type *bool* (boolean)

```
7 > 4
```

→ `True`

```
len("Odyssey") == 7
```

→ `True`

```
"rose" != "Rose"
```

→ `True`

- and others: `>`, `<`, `>=`, `<=`, `==`, `!=`



strings

quotes

- **single** and **double** quotes are **interchangeable**
 - choose whichever avoids escaping

```
s1 = "a string in double quotes contains 'single quotes'  
happily"
```

```
s2 = 'and vice "versa"'
```

- **triple** quotes hold **multi-line** text
 - useful for pasting in a passage

```
s3 = """triple quotes  
may span lines"""
```

special characters

- `\n` is a newline

```
print("line one\nline two")
```

→ line one

→ line two

- `\t` is a tab

```
print("word\tgloss")
```

→ word gloss

- real language data and files are full of them
 - lines of a transcript, columns of a glossary
- tsv (tab-separated values) files



string operations recap

- concatenation

```
"un" + "happy"
```

→ 'unhappy'

- repetition

```
"ha" * 3
```

→ 'hahaha'

- length

```
len("unhappy")
```

→ 7

- membership

```
"ppy" in "unhappy"
```

→ True



indexing

- every character has a position in a string
- positions count from **0**; negative positions count from the end
- `word = "duckling"`
- | | | | | | | | | |
|--|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| | d | u | c | k | l | i | n | g |
| | 0 | 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 | 6 | 7 |
- `word[0]`
 - $\rightarrow$ 'd'
- `word[-1]`
 - $\rightarrow$ 'g'

slicing

- slicing lets you **select a range of positions**
- `[start:stop]`: from `start` up to but **not including** `stop`
 - `word[0:4]`
 - $\rightarrow$ 'duck'
 - `word[4:8]`
 - $\rightarrow$ 'ling'
- why not-including? so the two halves reassemble with no overlap
 - `word[0:4] + word[4:8]`
 - $\rightarrow$ 'duckling'



slicing

- **blank start:** from the beginning
 - `word[:4]`
 - → 'duck'
- **blank stop:** to the end
 - `word[4:]`
 - → 'ling'
- `[:-1]`: everything but the last character
 - `word[:-1]`
 - → 'ducklin'

slicing

- the full picture: [start:end:step]
 - `word[::-1]`
 - → 'gnilkcud'

mutable vs. immutable

- a string is **immutable**
- it can never be changed in place
- operations build new strings

```
s = "rice"
```

```
s[0] = "n"
```

→ `TypeError: 'str' object does not support item assignment`

```
s = "n" + s[1:]      # build a new string instead
```

```
s
```

→ `'nice'`

- the same reason `s.lower()` without `s = s.lower()` changes nothing

strings

recap

```
s1 = 'the'
```

Operation	Description	Output
<code>len(s1)</code>	length of the string	3
<code>s1[0]</code>	indexing, 0-based	't'
<code>s1[-1]</code>	backwards indexing	'e'
<code>s1[0:3]</code>	slicing, extracts a substring	'the'
<code>s1[:2]</code>	slicing, extracts a substring	'th'
<code>s1 + ' sun'</code>	concatenation	'the sun'
<code>s1 * 3</code>	repetition	'thethethe'

strings

recap

```
a = 'Anna'
```

Operation

Output

```
a[::-1]
```

```
annA
```

```
'@'.join(a)
```

```
'A@n@n@a'
```

```
a[0:1]+"dmin"
```

```
'Admin'
```

```
a.find("a")
```

```
3
```

```
a.split()
```

```
['Anna']
```

```
"b@org.com".split("@")
```

```
['b', 'org.com']
```

linguistic reduplication

- many languages build words by **copying part of the word onto itself**
 - Tagalog: *bili* ‘buy’ → *bibili* ‘will buy’
 - Indonesian: *rumah* ‘house’ → *rumah-rumah* ‘houses’
 - English has a contrastive version: is it a “salad-salad”? (or just cold pasta)

activity

Classical Greek perfect

present		perfect	
<i>luō</i>	“I release”	<i>léluka</i>	“I have released”
<i>thuō</i>	“I sacrifice”	<i>téthuka</i>	“I have sacrificed”

- write code that builds the perfect from the present form
- tips
 - input: present form >> need to get rid of the ‘o’, `word_without_o = ...?`
 - output:
 - need to duplicate first consonant: `first_consonant = ...?`
 - add the -ka suffix: `print(x+y+"ka")`



list

list

- a *list* is a collection of arbitrarily typed objects
- positionally ordered
- no fixed size
- unlike strings, **mutable**

```
myList = [123, 'spam', 1.23]
```

```
birds = ["duck", "goose", "swan"]
```

```
empty = []
```


list

strings vs. lists

- `.split()` turns one string into a list of its space-separated pieces

```
line = "colorless green ideas sleep furiously"
```

```
tokens = line.split()
```

```
type(tokens)
```

→ list

- `len`, `in`, `.count()` all transfer
 - counting items, not characters

```
len(tokens)
```

→ 5

list

- slicing works similarly too

`tokens[0]`

→ 'colorless'

`tokens[-1]`

→ 'furiously'

- a slice of a list is a smaller list

`tokens[1:3]`

→ ['green', 'ideas']



list

- lists can contain lists
 - read the brackets left to right: row, then column

```
glosses = ["inu", "dog"], ["neko", "cat"], ["tori", "bird"]]
```

```
glosses[1]
```

```
→ ['neko', 'cat']
```

```
glosses[1][0]
```

```
→ 'neko'
```


list

- lists are **mutable**
- items in a list can be changed **in place**

```
x = ['a', 'b', 'c']
```

```
x.append('d')
```

```
x[2] = 'e'
```

```
x
```

```
→ ['a', 'b', 'e', 'd']
```

list

- `=` does not copy a list, it adds a second name for the **same** list

```
a = ["ba"]
```

```
b = a
```

```
a.append("baa")
```

```
b
```

```
→ ['ba', 'baa']
```

- mutate through either name and both see it
- a real copy: `a.copy()`

list

```
l = [123, 'spam', 1.23]
```

Operation	Description	Output
<code>len(l)</code>	length of the list	3
<code>l[1]</code>	indexing, 0-based	'spam'
<code>l[-1]</code>	backwards indexing	1.23
<code>l[0:2]</code>	slicing, extracts a sublist	[123, 'spam']
<code>l + [4, 5, 6]</code>	concatenation	[123, 'spam', 1.23, 4, 5, 6]
<code>l * 2</code>	repetition	[123, 'spam', 1.23, 123, 'spam', 1.23]



HW1

- released today on the course website and Canvas
- due next Thursday, Sep 10
- submit on Canvas as an .ipynb file
- general rule
 - you should only need to use content up until the day of release date



next time

- Thursday
 - control flow & dict
 - *Think Python*, Ch. 5, §§5.1–5.7: Conditionals
 - *Think Python*, Ch. 7, §§7.1 and 7.3–7.5: Loops, Updating, Counting
 - *Think Python*, Ch. 10, §§10.1–10.5: Dictionaries and Counters

logistics

- classes on week 6 (Sep 29 and Oct 1) will be asynchronous